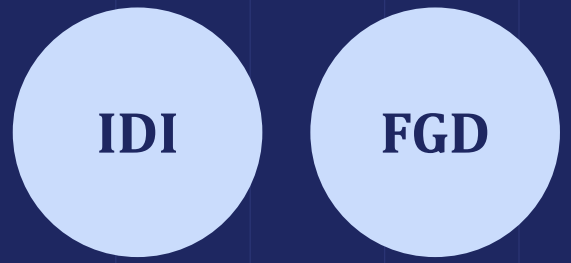
MARKETING RESEARCH · SESSION 6

Qualitative

Research Design

Conversation, not questionnaire – when, why, and how to use it credibly.



The two core methods – and the framework to choose between them

Session flow

Introduction	Conversation vs. Questionnaire
Concept 1	What qualitative research is, and the five conditions that call for it
Concept 2	Validity and rigour – pre-empting the ‘12 people?’ challenge
Concept 3	In-depth interviews – design, probing, and pitfalls
Concept 4	Focus group discussions – design, moderation, and pitfalls
Concept 5	IDI vs. FGD decision framework – applied to three short cases
Exercises & Wrap	RiseUp study design; InsurePlus critique; common mistakes

Filling in the P component of BLUEPRNT

When secondary data can't fully answer an information area, primary data collection begins.
Today: the first primary method – qualitative research.

This fills in what 'qualitative interview' or 'focus group' actually means when you write it in your BLUEPRNT.

Which method to use? How to design it?
How to conduct it credibly?
How to defend it to a sceptical analytics audience?

FROM SECONDARY RESEARCH

Some information areas require primary qualitative data – particularly when the purpose is **exploratory**, the **territory isn't mapped**, or **we need meaning**, not just prevalence.

Questionnaire or Conversation?

How do you feel about using AI tools at work?

Conversation

Meaning, texture, experience

What proportion of Indian knowledge workers use AI weekly?

Questionnaire

Prevalence, frequency, magnitude

The mistake most researchers make is using quantitative tools to answer qualitative questions, or vice versa.

1

What Qualitative Research Is

Its defining feature is not small sample size – that's a consequence. ***It's the purpose: the why and how.***

Five Conditions for Qualitative Research

1	**Territory is unexplored**	No prior picture of what drives the phenomenon – a survey would ask the wrong questions
2	**About meaning or language**	Brand perception, decision rationale – a 5-point scale can't say what '3' means
3	**Sensitive or complex topic**	Personal finance, health, stigma – questionnaires trigger social desirability bias
4	**Context and process matter**	How a decision unfolds over time – a cross-sectional survey freezes one moment
5	**Need to generate hypotheses**	Constructs must be grounded in real language before they can be measured well

Qualitative research is the code review before the deployment –
It ensures what you measure is what actually matters to the people you're studying.

What Qualitative Research CAN and CANNOT produce

CAN PRODUCE	CANNOT PRODUCE
Rich understanding of constructs & language	Statistically defensible prevalence estimates
Hypotheses grounded in consumer reality	Confirmation those hypotheses are true for the population
Deep insight from a small, purposive sample	Generalisation to all consumers or markets
Understanding why a pattern exists	Precise measurement of how large or frequent it is
New constructs the researcher hadn’t anticipated	Definitive answers with quantified confidence

The Fintech App's Drop-off Mystery

SCENARIO A fintech company's payment app has a well-documented drop-off problem: **43% of users** who begin the onboarding process do not complete it.

The product analytics team has identified exactly where users drop off (the bank account linking step) and how long they spend before dropping off *(average 4.2 minutes)*.

The head of product asks: 'We know where they drop off and when. We don't know why.'

The data analyst suggests a pop-up survey with ten possible reasons.

The qualitative research manager pushes back.

DISCUSSION PROMPT Which of the five qualitative conditions does this situation satisfy? Why is the pop-up survey inadequate, and what would qualitative research produce that the survey cannot?

The Fintech App's Drop-off Mystery

43% drop off at bank account linking (avg. 4.2 min).
Analytics know where & when – **not why**.
Analyst proposes a pop-up survey with 10 reason options.

WHY THE SURVEY FAILS

It assumes the 10 options already contain the real reason.

If users lapse for an unanticipated reason – logistics, not trust or UX – the survey collects high-quality data about the wrong explanations entirely.

WHAT IDIs WOULD PRODUCE

Actual language users use to describe what stopped them.

The cognitive/emotional sequence in those 4.2 minutes, and hypotheses grounded in real experience – ready for a quantitative follow-up if needed.

2

Qualitative Validity and Rigour

‘Is this really research?’

Four quantitative criteria, four qualitative equivalents

Internal validity *Are we measuring what we claim to measure?*	**Credibility**	Do findings represent participants' actual experience? Member checking, triangulation
External validity *Can we generalise these findings beyond this study?*	**Transferability**	Not statistical generalisation – thick description lets readers judge applicability
Reliability *Would the same study produce the same results?*	**Dependability**	Audit trail: documented process, coding decisions, reflexivity
Objectivity *Are the findings free from researcher bias?*	**Confirmability**	Findings grounded in data – quotes and evidence, not researcher assertion

Not ‘is this big enough?’ *Rather*, ‘did this reach saturation?’

Theoretical saturation: the point where new interviews stop producing new themes, categories, or insights.

Typically 8–15 interviews for a homogeneous population; 12–20+ for heterogeneous groups. A study saturating at 10 is more rigorous than one that runs 25 without ever checking.

Purposive sampling

Sample includes the RIGHT people for the question – not a convenient cross-section

Thick description

Verbatim quotes and process detail so a reader can judge credibility and transferability

The Sceptical CMO

SCENARIO A marketing research team presents findings from 14 in-depth interviews with urban homeowners who had purchased a new AC in the last 12 months.

The findings show that consumers consistently describe energy efficiency as 'important' but consistently place it third or fourth in their actual purchase hierarchy, behind cooling performance, brand reputation, and price.

The CMO reviews the findings and says: 'Fourteen people? You can't draw conclusions from that. I need a 500-person survey before I believe this.'

The research lead's job is to respond.

DISCUSSION PROMPT

How should the research lead respond to the CMO? What does the qualitative study establish, and what would a 500-person survey add and not add?

Two challenges, two responses

'12 people is not representative.'

Correct – **and it's not trying to be**. Depth and breadth are different goods; you cannot get both from the same method simultaneously.

'It's just the researcher's interpretation.'

Partially true – which is why the audit trail matters. Transparent data and analysis let another researcher reach broadly similar conclusions.

In the blueprint: state which criteria apply (credibility, transferability, dependability, confirmability) and how each will be established.

The Sceptical CMO

14 IDIs find: consumers call energy efficiency 'important' but rank it 3rd/4th behind cooling, brand, price. CMO: 'Fourteen people? I need a 500-person survey before I believe this.'

ALREADY ESTABLISHED

The gap exists, the language around it, the competing considerations, and a credible explanation for why it happens (abstract/long-term vs. immediate/concrete).

WHAT A SURVEY WOULD ADD / NOT ADD

Adds: prevalence & demographic variation. Does NOT add: better understanding of why the gap exists – that depth is already there.

3

In-Depth Interviews (IDIs)

Designed to surface what the researcher did not know to ask in advance.

Selection, Sample Size, Guide Design

1	**Participant selection**	1–3 purposive inclusion criteria tied to the research question	*Recruiting convenient rather than relevant participants*
2	**Sample size & saturation**	Plan 8–10 (homogeneous) or 12–15 (heterogeneous); check every 3–4 interviews	*Committing to a fixed number with no saturation check*
3	**Discussion guide design**	Warm-up → core probing → closing; open, non-leading questions	*Writing the guide like a questionnaire with closed, leading questions*

Mode, Recording, Analysis

4	**Interview mode**	Face-to-face, telephone, or video – fit to research need, not convenience. Sensitive topics: phone/video may increase disclosure	*Choosing mode by convenience, not design fit*
5	**Recording & transcription**	Audio recording + verbatim transcription is the gold standard	*Analysing from notes instead of transcripts – injects interviewer bias early*
6	**Analysis approach**	Thematic analysis across ALL transcripts – claims need multi-participant support	*Over-representing vivid or memorable participants*

Core IDI skill.
One probe follows every substantive response

Elaboration	*'Can you tell me more about that?' – develops an unfinished topic*
Clarification	*'What did you mean by [word]?' – resolves ambiguous terms*
Example	*'Walk me through a specific time when…' – moves abstract to concrete*
Echo / silence	*Repeat their last phrase, or simply pause – most powerful, most underused*
Reason	*'Why is that important to you?' – the most analytically valuable level*

Almost never use: leading questions ('So price was the main issue?') or confirmatory probes ('That makes sense, right?') – both compromise confirmability.

Design Decision	Options and Guidance
1. Participant selection (purposive sampling)	Define the criterion for inclusion based on who has the experience or knowledge most relevant to the research question. For a study of premium product churn, the relevant participants are premium churned customers – not a random cross-section. Define one to three inclusion criteria; more than three tends to make recruitment impossible.
2. Sample size and saturation planning	Plan for 8–10 interviews as a starting point for a homogeneous participant group; 12–15 for a more heterogeneous group. Plan saturation checks after every third or fourth interview and stop when no new themes are emerging. Do not specify a fixed final sample size in advance if the study is genuinely exploratory.

Design Decision	Options and Guidance
3. Discussion guide design	Structure the guide in three sections: ○ warm-up (broad, non-threatening questions to build rapport), ○ core probing (the main themes and sub-themes tied to the research's information areas), and ○ closing (a forward-looking or reflective question that often produces the most honest responses). Write probes for each core question: 'Can you tell me more about that?', 'What did you mean by [word they used]?', 'Can you walk me through what happened?'
4. Interview mode	Face-to-face (highest rapport, highest cost and logistical complexity), telephone (lower rapport but accessible for geographically dispersed samples), video call (compromise between face-to-face and telephone; increasingly standard). For sensitive topics, telephone or video may be better. Face-to-facecan increase social desirability pressure.

Design Decision	Options and Guidance
5. Recording and transcription	Audio recording (with participant consent) plus verbatim transcription is the gold standard. Notes-only interviews produce an immediate interpretation of what was said rather than a record of what was actually said, which compromises the audit trail. Video recording adds non-verbal data but increases participant self-consciousness.
6. Analysis approach	Thematic analysis is the most widely used approach for marketing research IDIs: the researcher reads all transcripts, identifies recurring themes and sub-themes, codes the data, and synthesises findings into a structured narrative with supporting quotes. The key quality check at this stage is to present claims only when supported by evidence from multiple participants, not from a single interesting interview.

The Urban Grocery Delivery Platform's Lapsed User Study

SCENARIO QuickBasket is an urban grocery delivery app with a growing cohort of '**lapsed users**' – *customers who signed up, placed between one and three orders, and then stopped using the app entirely without deleting it*. Internal analytics show the lapse typically occurs within the first 30 days. The product team has a list of hypotheses (delivery speed, product quality, pricing, UX confusion) but no data on which is most important or whether there are other causes they have not identified. The research team has been asked to design an IDI study.
The research manager has drafted the following discussion guide core section:
Q1: Was the delivery speed a problem for you?
Q2: How was the quality of the products you received?
Q3: Did you find the prices too high compared to other apps?
Q4: Was the app interface confusing or difficult to use?
Q5: Would you say you stopped using the app mainly because of one of these four reasons?

DISCUSSION What is wrong with this discussion guide, and how would you redesign the core section to produce genuinely useful qualitative data?

QuickBasket's Lapsed User Study

Draft guide asks: 'Was delivery a problem?' 'Was quality OK?' 'Were prices too high?' 'Was the UX confusing?' – all closed, all confirm existing hypotheses.

FOUR PROBLEMS

- All closed/leading – no room for unanticipated reasons
- Tests four pre-formed hypotheses, doesn't explore
- Sequencing frames the answer before it's given
- No probes – reads like a tick-box checklist

REDESIGNED OPENING

'Walk me through the last time you used QuickBasket – from opening the app to after your order arrived.'

Then: 'Did anything make you think differently about the app afterward?' – letting participants define what mattered, in their own words.

The Hospital's Patient Discharge Experience

SCENARIO

A private hospital chain wants to understand why discharged inpatients give the hospital a low rating on the 'experience of going home' dimension of its patient satisfaction survey, despite scoring well on all clinical dimensions.

The hospital has identified that the low rating clusters in the first three days after discharge.

The research head proposes IDIs with 15 recently discharged inpatients (within two weeks of discharge) who rated the discharge experience as 1 or 2 out of 5.

DISCUSSION PROMPT

Evaluate the sampling decision (only low-raters), the timing of interviews (within two weeks), and propose the opening section of the discussion guide for this study.

4

Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)

The group interaction itself generates data individual interviews cannot.

Composition, Number Of Groups, Group Size

1	**Group composition**	Homogeneous enough for comfort, not so much that no productive tension exists	*Mixing very different power levels (managers + reports)*
2	**Number of groups**	3–4 groups per segment as a minimum; run to saturation	*One or two groups treated as definitive*
3	**Group size**	6–8 participants is standard	*Recruiting 10–12 and treating full attendance as fine – recruit for 8, arrive at 6–8*

Moderator Guide, Venue, Analysis

4	**Moderator guide**	Warm-up/core/closing, 3–5 core themes framed to invite comparison & disagreement	*Too many topics – moderator rushes rather than follows threads*
5	**Venue & setting**	Neutral, comfortable venue – NEVER the client's office	*Holding the FGD at the company office – participants self-censor*
6	**Analysis**	Unit of analysis is the GROUP, not the individual – consensus & disagreement both matter	*Analysing as if 8 simultaneous IDIs – misses group dynamics entirely*

Five group dynamics to anticipate and manage

Dominant participant	*Direct questions to quieter members by name; redirect eye contact after they speak*
Silent participant	*Same technique – invite by name, scan the group rather than returning to one person*
False consensus	*Push once for dissent: 'Does anyone see it differently?' – never accept the first agreement as final*
Off-topic tangents	*Acknowledge and explicitly close before redirecting – never just ignore*
Group polarisation	*Don't resolve it – explore it as data: 'What leads to such different reactions?'*

The Beverage Company's New Product Concept Test

SCENARIO NaturePure is a beverage company launching a range of functional beverages. Before finalising the product range, the marketing team wants to test three product concepts among urban working adults aged 28–40 who consume health and wellness products.
The product manager suggests six focus groups (three with men, three with women, eight participants each).
The research manager agrees on the segment split but raises a concern about the discussion guide, which consists of: (1) a product concept card for each of the three beverages; (2) a rating form asking participants to score each concept on five attributes (taste appeal, health benefit credibility, packaging appeal, price acceptability, purchase intent); (3) a final open question: 'Any other comments?'

DISCUSSION PROMPT What type of data will the proposed design produce, and is it the right type for the research question? What is missing from the discussion guide, and how would you redesign it?

The Banking App's Trust Study

SCENARIO

A digital bank is considering a new feature that would allow users to set savings goals and automatically transfer money from their salary account to a dedicated savings account each month.

The product team wants to understand how users feel about automated money transfers and whether trust in the bank's systems is a barrier to adoption.

The research manager proposes FGDs with existing digital bank customers.

DISCUSSION PROMPT

Is an FGD the right method for this research question, or would IDIs be more appropriate?

What specific design features of the FGD would you build in to address the sensitivity of the financial trust topic?

NaturePure's New Product Concept Test

6 FGDs proposed to test 3 beverage concepts.
Guide: concept cards + a 5-attribute rating FORM per concept + 'any other comments?'

The problem: rating forms make participants work independently – eliminating the group interaction that makes FGDs valuable in the first place.

Redesigned opening (before any attribute is named):

'When you first see this concept, what comes to mind?'

'Who do you think this drink is for?'

'When would you reach for something like this?'

'What would make you trust the health benefit claim is real?'

Rating forms, if used at all, come at the end – after qualitative exploration, not instead of it.

5

The IDI vs. FGD Decision Framework

Not about cost or efficiency – about which method produces the data you need.

Five criteria to evaluate for every qualitative study

CRITERION	→ IDI	→ FGD
Nature of phenomenon	Individual & cognitive	Social: norms, peer influence
Topic sensitivity	High – finance, health, stigma	Low–moderate sensitivity. Consumer preferences, product reactions
Depth vs. breadth	One complete individual narrative	Range & prevalence of views
Group dynamics as data	Would contaminate individual data	Are themselves the phenomenon
Access & logistics	Dispersed, demanding schedules	Locally accessible, compatible schedules

The memorable version for a live client question

IDI is almost always right when…

Personal finance/health topics · why a specific individual decided something · professionals unlikely to speak freely in a group · need a complete individual narrative

FGD is almost always right when…

How a group/community thinks · need the range and relative prevalence of views · concept testing · topic generates productive group discussion

The grey zone – where you genuinely need to think

Household purchase decisions (individual or joint?) · workplace behaviour (honest among peers?) · online behaviour (individual but socially shaped) · topics where sensitivity varies widely across the population

Luxury Car Purchase

SCENARIO A premium car brand wants to understand the decision journey of Indian consumers who purchased their first luxury car (priced above ₹50 lakhs). The brand is interested in: what triggered the decision to upgrade to a luxury segment, how family members were involved in the decision, and what emotional and social factors shaped the final brand and model choice.

Teen Social Media Behaviour

SCENARIO A smartphone brand wants to understand how Indian teenagers aged 15–18 use social media platforms — which platforms they use for which purposes, how they manage their online identities, and how platform choices are influenced by what their friend groups are using. The brand is developing a device with a teen-focused UI.

Employee Return-to-Office Policy

SCENARIO A large IT services company has mandated that all employees return to office five days a week after three years of hybrid working. HR wants to understand how employees feel about the policy, their concerns, and what would make the return easier. Employees range from junior analysts (22–26 years) to senior managers (40–50 years).

Three short cases, quick verdicts

A **Luxury Car Purchase**

Decision journey, family involvement, emotional/social factors behind a ₹50L+ buy

IDI

B **Teen Social Media Use**

Platform choice shaped explicitly by peer groups and shared norms

FGD

C **Return-to-Office Policy**

Junior-to-senior staff; moderate sensitivity; real power dynamics

Both

RiseUp Online Career Coaching Platform

18,000 registered users; only 23% complete 3+ paid sessions.
MRP: what discourages continued engagement, and what would motivate more?

1. Method selection – IDI, FGD, or both? Justify with the decision framework
2. Participant selection – who, and which inclusion criteria?
3. Sample size plan – how many, and how will you check saturation?
4. Discussion guide outline – warm-up, 3 core Qs (one per IA), closing, 2+ probes each
5. Rigour measures – which of the 4 criteria, and how established?

Strong answer favours IDI (individual cognitive process, possible sensitivity, needs narrative depth) – not FGD for 'speed.'

InsurePlus Health Insurance Claims Study

3 FGDs of 10, all claimants mixed (renewed + non-renewed + company staff in the room), closed leading questions, moderator notes only, no rigour measures.

Mixing renewers & non-renewers	*Dilutes the specific research question; non-renewers self-censor*
Company staff in the room	*Catastrophic contamination – participants moderate complaints in front of staff*
Closed, leading questions	*Frames the answer instead of exploring experience*
Groups of 10, no saturation check	*Too large to moderate; may run past or stop before saturation*
Notes-only analysis	*Captures the moderator's impression, not the data*

Method verdict: the topic satisfies Conditions 1, 2 & 3 from Concept 1 – recommend 10–15 IDIs with non-renewers, by phone or video.

Common Student Mistakes

1. Writing a discussion guide that reads like a questionnaire – *test*: could every question be answered in one word?
2. Stating a sample size without a saturation-check mechanism to justify it.
3. Recommending FGDs for topics needing individual depth because ‘more people feels more objective.’
4. Treating FGD transcripts as 8 simultaneous IDIs – missing the group dynamics that ARE the data.
5. Calling two disconnected phases ‘mixed methods’ without specifying how qual findings feed the quant design.